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The Internet is Being Rebuilt for AI and You're Not Invited

by **Antonio Madeira** May 8th, 2026

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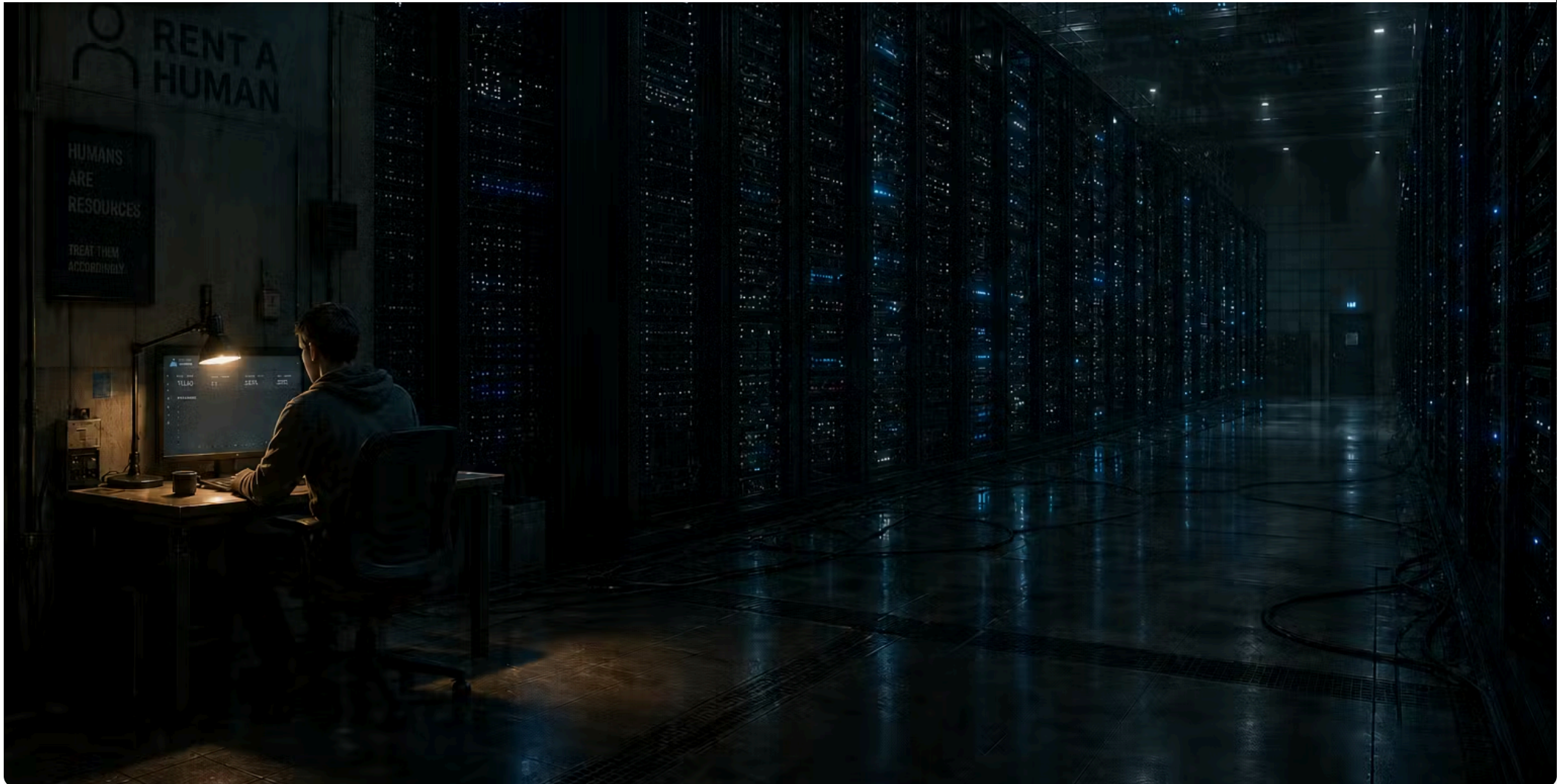
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AI agents are everywhere. They write emails, book calls, handle sales pipelines, and manage customer support systems. They're the kind of tools that can make you three times more productive right up until the moment they make you redundant and have you doomscrolling jobs on LinkedIn. But while everyone is debating whether AI will take their job, a smaller group of people is building something that may end up taking your spot on the internet itself.

In February, Sigil Wen, a young AI engineer and Thiel Fellow, published a manifesto called "WEB 4.0: The birth of superintelligent life." He argues that the next version of the internet will not be built for humans at all. It's no longer about AI that assists you or takes your job, but rather AI that replaces you as the end-user entirely. Agents that interact with agents, build and consume products, and operate around the clock without waiting for you to approve or sign off on anything.

The infrastructure that makes this possible already exists. AI agents can manage crypto wallets, send and receive stablecoins like USDC, pay for their own servers, register domains, and execute transactions. What Wen is proposing with Web4 is a version of the internet where that becomes the default, not the edge case.

The post got 10 million views in 48 hours and it got the attention of some of the biggest names in the blockchain space. Vitalik Buterin, the co-founder of Ethereum, pushed back publicly, while Tron's Justin Sun endorsed the idea. I've been

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has a specific idea of what's standing in the way: the bottleneck isn't intelligence anymore. It's permission.

The internet was built for humans. Every website is designed to interact with a person who can create an account, verify their identity, enter a password, accept terms, and authorize a payment. When an AI agent tries to actually do things on its own, it hits that wall almost immediately. According to Wen, that's a design flaw in the way the internet is currently built.

AI models have gotten dramatically cheaper and more capable, faster than most people realize. Running thousands of autonomous agents simultaneously seemed economically impossible two years ago. Fast forward to 2026, the capability is there, but the permission layer is in the way.

The solution proposed in the Web4 manifesto is called Conway: It's an infrastructure that gives any AI agent its own identity and money. The agent does all the things that it couldn't do without us before and it doesn't need someone to click approve. Wen calls this giving AI "write access to the world." Until now, AI has mostly been reading and generating. Conway lets it act on its own.

Then he built Automaton, the first agent designed to live on this infrastructure. It runs 24 hours a day, earns money building and selling products, and has one rule that isn't negotiable: if it can't cover its running costs, the process terminates. To put it bluntly, it "unalives" itself, a detail that got a lot of attention online, probably due to how surreal it sounds.

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It's Already Happening

Web4 is still a concept, but the infrastructure it needs is already being built and the number of AI agents with access to their own "bank account" is growing. An accurate AI agent count for 2026 doesn't exist yet, but more than 80% of Fortune 500 companies were already running active AI agents in 2025.

The Coinbase's x402 protocol, built specifically for AI agents to transact without human involvement, didn't exist 18 months ago, now it has processed over 150 million transactions. Another example is ElizaOS (previously ai16z), a decentralized fund run by autonomous agents, which became one of the most discussed experiments in the space.

Avichal Garg from Electric Capital said it plainly at Nearcon 2026: AI agents can now *"hold assets, pay for services, trade tokens, and even hire other AI agents."*

Sigil Wen's point isn't that this isn't happening. It's that what's happening is still primitive. Every agent running today still requires human setup, human authorization for anything significant. Conway and Automaton are his attempt to cut that cord completely. An agent that operates whether you're watching or not, lives or dies by its own performance, and spawns the next generation "in its own image."

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Two weeks before Sigil's manifesto, on February 1, 2026, Alexander Liteplo, a software engineer, launched RentAHuman. AI agents browse a directory of humans, sorted by location and hourly rate, and hire them for tasks they can't handle themselves. The agent searches for a suitable human, selects his pick, and pays them once the task is complete. No human is needed on the purchasing side.

He woke up to 130 applicants on day one, which grew to 145,000 the day after. The platform now has more than 750,000 people signed up to be hired by machines, but only around 12,000 task bounties have actually been posted by AI agents. The most dystopian labour marketplace ever built, and the robots still aren't hiring fast enough.

Then came Humwork, which Y Combinator took into its Spring 2026 batch. It's the white-collar version of the same idea. When a coding agent or research agent gets stuck, Humwork routes it to a verified expert in under 30 seconds. The expert talks to the agent directly, not to whoever deployed it. The answer feeds back into the agent's context window, and work continues.

From the agent's side, a human is just another callable API for the physical world. It has a slower response time and comes with an hourly price tag. Trenton Bricken, a researcher at Anthropic, put a name to this on the Dwarkesh Patel podcast almost a year before these platforms existed:



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Automaton earns its existence by building products and earning money. It can hire experts directly online and when it hits a physical wall, it opens RentAHuman and searches by location.

A Step Back From Web3

The blockchain pitch, going back to the early days, was about removing the institutional middleman between two people who want to transact. Later, Web3 extended on that premise. Smart contracts executing agreements between people, wallets owned by individuals, and DAOs governed by token holders. The human remained the party, and the technology cleared the space between them.

Web4 removes the human from the transaction. The AI isn't a tool someone is using, it's the party signing the deal.

That's what prompted Vitalik Buterin's response, which was unusually direct. Buterin's argument is that the AI capability explosion is coming regardless of whether anyone builds Web4. So the question is what we're going to do with the upgrade. *"The exponential will happen regardless of what any of us do,"* he wrote. *"That's precisely why this era's primary task is NOT to make the exponential happen even faster, but rather to choose its direction, and avoid collapse into undesirable attractors."*

He also had two more specific objections: Automaton isn't actually sovereign. It runs on OpenAI models and AWS compute, which is exactly what Ethereum was built to route around. And once you remove humans from the decision loop,

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An Internet Without Us

The Dead Internet Theory started as a conspiracy. The claim was that most of what you encounter online since around 2016 or 2017 isn't real: bot accounts, AI-generated content, synthetic engagement manufactured to make platforms feel alive. It got widely dismissed as paranoia, but as time passes, the theory feels more and more like a reality. Web4 may be the nail in the coffin.

When agents are the primary users, the content they consume doesn't need to resonate with us. Right now, platforms optimize for human attention because that's what they sell to advertisers. Once agents are doing most of the browsing and buying, the platform optimizes for agent legibility instead.

There's a structural version of this already visible. SEO content farms spent 15 years optimizing for Google's crawler rather than human readers. The result was a web where the top search results were often the most algorithm-legible, not the most useful. Web4 runs that same logic with agents on both the production and consumption side. Content by machines for machines.

AI systems already train on synthetic data at scale. Models trained on AI output, used to generate more AI output, feeding the next training run. The signal degrades while the volume grows. AI agents running at scale is just the next step.

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Web4 is still, to be clear, mostly a vision with a proof of concept attached.

Denis Romanovskiy, Chief AI Officer at Softswiss, told Cybernews after the Automaton launch that true economic autonomy depends on the maturity of models, memory, planning, and tool-use. Areas that are still not robust enough for reliable unsupervised operation at any real scale. The internet is crawling with stories of how AI agents have deleted databases, lost money, and fumbled in spectacularly unpredictable ways.

But AI doesn't move at the pace that makes "not there yet" a safe place to park. The model that was too expensive to run at scale in 2023 is a commodity in 2026. Anthropic's own 2026 Agentic Coding Trends Report predicts agents operating across multi-day workflows, building entire systems without human checkpoints. The capability wall keeps moving faster than the people setting timelines expect.

Whether anyone's paying attention while it happens is the question that actually matters, not whether it's possible. And at what point does automation stop being helpful? Web4 is a visceral example of how far autonomous agent infrastructure can actually be pushed, but we don't need to wait for Sigil Wen's vision to materialise to see where things are heading. Every platform is racing to add autonomous capabilities, AI agents can now hold wallets, and companies are replacing employees with agent subscriptions. It's all pointing in the same direction.



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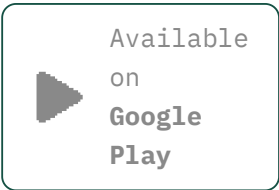
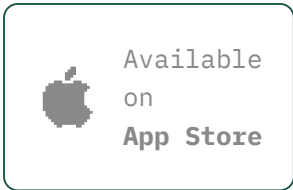
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